in under two hours," he reveals. "A producer would put on a loop or make a beat, and I'd sit on the couch, spitting out lines and figuring out melodies. Songs like 'Blush', 'If I Cannot Be Yours', and 'Under the Stars' were written like that." However, working across multiple cities with various producers left the album feeling somewhat fragmented. Enter co-producer Nick Ruth (known for his work with Carly Rae Jepsen and Zara Larsson), who came on board to unify the record's sonic landscape. "Nick was instrumental in making it feel cohesive. We spent days swapping out parts, tweaking arrangements and, eventually, re-recording all the vocals in LA over two weeks to really get them right," he adds.

If it feels like Kuhad releases more English tracks than Hindi, it is perhaps because all three albums are in English. The singer insists that he has released several Hindi EPs and singles for his listeners. "I get this question a lot! In my discography since 2013, I've literally alternated between Hindi and English releases," he points out.

Now splitting his time equally between Jaipur, Delhi and LA, Kuhad finds that his lifestyle offers a healthy equilibrium. While India remains home for family and high-octane press cycles, LA—where he set up a home a few years ago—provides the quiet, solitary space he craves. "LA is where I get 'me time' and do creative work because it's quiet and grounding," he says.

Kuhad is also gearing up for his film debut with director Dar Gai's *Drowning*, where he plays a Delhi-based indie musician. The story is reportedly inspired by his own song, 'Drown'. Even as his global footprint grows, Kuhad remains focused on what he's always done best—translating personal, internal experiences into song. ■

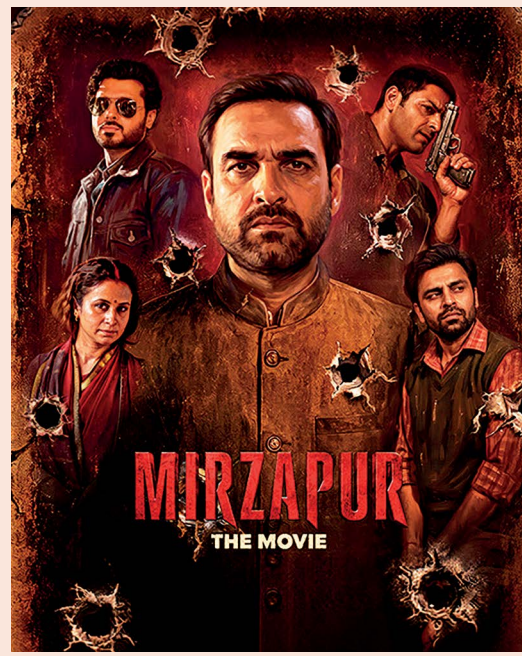
—Deepali Dhingra

CINEMA ▼

GOING TO THE MOVIES

MIRZAPUR IS MAKING THE LEAP FROM STREAMING PHENOMENON TO THEATRICAL SPECTACLE

Few OTT characters have inspired hero worship as much as *Mirzapur*'s Kaleen Bhaiyya (Pankaj Tripathi), Guddu (Ali Fazal) and Munna (Divyendu). It's no surprise then that when Farhan Akhtar and Ritesh Sidhwani of Excel Entertainment presented Amazon Prime with a new iteration of *Mirzapur*, one for the big screen, Gaurav Gandhi, the platform's vice president, APAC & ANZ, was all ears.



"It was a no-brainer for us," says Gandhi. "When we sat through the idea of what is the biggest and massiest [sic] show we can think of—and we have done a few—the world that *Mirzapur* has created and how its characters have evolved over the seasons stood tall. There is a whole bunch of things from which you can create alternative universes and parallel shows." Unlike season three of *Mirzapur*, which was Munna-less, given his death in the preceding season, this one has the audience-puller character because it's a prequel to season one. While all key characters reprise their roles, Jitendra Kumar replaces Vikrant Massey as Bablu.

Greenlighting a film for one of Prime's most beloved shows is both an obvious and a risky decision. Gandhi was confident it would pay dividends at the box office. "The show has appeal across metros and small towns. It can bring fandoms of each character to cinemas."

Whether *Mirzapur* starts a trend of OTT platforms betting big on long-format titles releasing in theatres remains to be seen. For Gandhi, though, it meets Amazon Prime's policy of giving viewers "the opportunity to watch things across multiple screens and access points". The platform has a slate of films that it released straight on digital (*Subedaar*, *System*), while Amazon Studios has a select few that got theatrical rollout (*Superboys of Malegaon*). "It's a judgement call, a thoughtful, joint decision, made in tandem with our partners as to which film should go to theatres," adds Gandhi. The final verdict, though, lies with the audience. ■

MIRZAPUR'S CHARACTERS AND STORYLINES GIVE AMPLE OPPORTUNITIES FOR SPIN-OFF TALES, ACCORDING TO AMAZON PRIME

—Suhani Singh

The film is out on Sept. 4